

Backgrounds

As they are not beings of Glamour, Hsien cannot make use of the Chimera or Dreamers Backgrounds. Other Backgrounds listed here describe concepts similar to but ultimately different than those used by the Kithain, and so are given different names to set them apart, even if they serve a similar purpose in the story.

Auspicious Treasure (Treasure)

These items, created by powerful Hsien, internalize a specific I Chih. It can only realize that effect, but the Hsien need not understand that I Chih or even that Alchemy to use it. Most will still require an infusion of Yugen to operate. For every dot of the Auspicious Treasure Background, the item in question may reproduce an I Chih of that level, or a cohort effect of one level lower.

Dragon Nest (Holding)

Dragon nests are confluences of dragon lines, sites of great power that naturally generate Yugen — one point per day per dot in this Background. Many dragon nests are actually open to the public, housing shrines or temples that serve the mortal populace, but the Hsien who control them guard them jealously.

Ownership of a dragon nest is fraught with danger, since most shen prize them equally and even Hsien will often stop at nothing to obtain them. Courts routinely struggle over dragon nests, and if your character is part of that court, she is responsible for defending it on that court's behalf.

Jade Talisman

True Jade that has been awakened, either with Wu Tan or through some other method, is much desired by all shen, but it is especially prized by Hsien because it is able to store points of Yugen — as many as the rating of the Background purchased. Hsien may draw on this pool of Yugen as long as they have the True Jade somewhere on their person. She may also sacrifice dots in this Background to generate a point of Yugen immediately, though this does not regenerate — the jade tarnishes and cracks slightly, and if every point in this background is sacrificed, it crumbles to dust.

Pakua

While pakua usually refers to a small mirror bordered by the eight trigrams of the I Ching that is used to deflect bad luck or the unwanted attentions of dark forces, when speaking of Hsien it refers to a preternatural ability to hide amongst mortals. Much like the Mists, Pakua covers the Hsien's tracks when she's forced to employ her power — without it, people will certainly remember the local bartender transforming into a hissing, spitting feline nightmare.

One dot of Pakua adds 2 to the difficulty to the attempts of others to recognize the Hsien's nature. Every subsequent dot of Pakua adds a required success to locate them properly. Shinma do not experience the additional difficulty imposed by Pakua, but must overcome the prerequisite successes on a Shentao roll.

Influence (Title)

Hsien do not employ a system of vassalage, but Courts do have a distinct hierarchy, with subordinates obeying superiors who are responsible for their wellbeing and behavior. In practice, things may differ. There is no formal system of inheritance, however, and even the highest-ranking members are not “noble” because of anything but their accomplishments (or, more often, their connections).

Influence confers a position within a court, with importance and authority rising in proportion to the dots in the Background. The Yü and Li Shen courts are most concerned with grand nomenclature, while others (particularly the Xian Mun) place less emphasis on such things. Still, even without a grand title attached to one's name, Hsien know who is important and who is not.

- ☉ **Basic:** The character has influence over a neighborhood in a city, or over a large village.
- ☉☉ **Minor:** The character has influence over a town, or a ward in a small city.
- ☉☉☉ **Useful:** The character has influence over a small city, an entire district in a larger city, or over wide counties in rural areas.
- ☉☉☉☉ **Significant:** The character has influence over an enormous city (think Tokyo or Beijing), or over small prefectures or minor provinces.
- ☉☉☉☉☉ **Incredible:** The character has influence over a major province or region (think all of Kanto or Guangdong).

Kwannon-jin: Hirayanu & Kamuii

Once, the Hirayanu were the lowest of the gods in the celestial hierarchy. Taking the shapes of animals, they carried out the August Personage of Jade's commands with regards to nature. In the modern day, cut off as they are from their former masters, Hirayanu have taken to mortal society instead, and carved out niches of their own. The Hirayanu are presented first, and include fu hsi, heng po, nyan, and tanuki.

Once, the Kamuii were the intermediaries between the Hirayanu and the greater gods of the celestial bureaucracy, and guided their lesser cousins in their labors. Cast out alongside them, they now must contend with the shifting vagaries of mortal nature, which is so frequently at odds with the elemental purity they express. The Kamuii descriptions appear after the Hirayanu (beginning p. 428) and include the chu-ih-yu, chu jung, hou-chi, komuko, and sui-jen.

Fu hsi

Curious, ever curious, the fu hsi. These snake people are renowned for wisdom and deliberation, and for taking their time over questions of great import. Too much time, indeed — a question that is not easily solved demands the fu hsi's full attention, with such trifles as food or sleep left by the wayside. Often, it is up to their friends to shake them out of this trance. The fu hsi take great care with their manners, and love to